

Racial Representation in Local Government and Racial Disparities in Policing

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Abstract

We use statewide North Carolina data to examine how racial and ethnic representation on city councils affects policing. Focusing on traffic stops, we document large Black-white disparities in post-stop outcomes, including arrests and citations. Using a difference-in-differences design around narrowly decided elections of nonwhite councilmembers, we find that increased nonwhite representation significantly reduces Black-white disparities in stops and actions taken. The reduction in “action taken” among Black drivers reflects a substitution away from citations and toward verbal warnings. Estimates with and without officer fixed effects are similar, suggesting that the findings are driven primarily by changes in individual officer behavior rather than shifts in police-force composition.

¹Author order is randomized using the AEA Author Randomization Tool. All data are publicly available and can be shared upon publication. We (Wang, Jones, Zeng) have no relevant disclosures.

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1 INTRODUCTION

Black drivers throughout the United States are disproportionately stopped by police and disproportionately searched when stopped; while obvious from the most basic statistics, the geographic scope and magnitude of this problem has been laid bare by new large-scale databases of traffic stops (Baumgartner et al., 2017; Pierson et al., 2020). Moreover, there is ample evidence that said gaps in stops are discriminatory. The racial gap in stops narrows after dark, when it is harder for the officer to see the driver (Grogger and Ridgeway, 2006). When drivers of color are searched, officers are less likely to find contraband, indicating a lower threshold for initiating the stop and search (Pierson et al., 2020).

Racial gaps in traffic stops, and the consequences therein, are of course one piece of a broader system of racialized policing and racism in the criminal justice system. Despite heightened public attention and the implementation of reforms aimed at reducing these disparities — ranging from broader racial representation in police forces, as well as the adoption of measures such as body cameras, de-escalation training, Department of Justice (DOJ) investigations, federal consent decrees, and external court monitoring – racial gaps in policing persist.

Ultimately, the impact of any of these policies depends on the degree of enforcement and, potentially, the simultaneous introduction of a suite of other (potentially unobserved) reforms. In US municipalities, oversight of police agencies ultimately occurs in city council and mayors' offices. We therefore step back from specific policies and ask: how does diverse racial representation amongst elected officials in a municipality (especially, city council) impact racial disparities in policing outcomes? The outcomes we primarily focus on in this paper are traffic stops (for reasons like, for example, speed limit or vehicle equipment violations) and the actions taken by officers conditional on stopping a driver (e.g., whether a citation vs. a verbal warning is issued) – both of which are actions where officers have

substantial discretion.

We draw on data on police traffic stops from North Carolina throughout the 2010s. North Carolina is a setting that provides a unique opportunity to explore our research questions. First, there is a rich (nearly) statewide dataset on the universe of traffic stops. Second, unique features of North Carolina’s voter registration files facilitate identifying the race of city council candidates at a statewide level – that is, for municipalities small and large. This would not be as readily possible in other states.

In our analysis, we first document large baseline disparities in whether an officer issues citation or arrests a driver conditional on making a stop. This is true in the simplest specification and in a rich specification including an array of fixed effects and controls, including officer fixed effects. Black drivers are 1.4-3.8 percentage points more likely than white drivers to receive fines or face arrest following a traffic stop.

We then adopt a difference-in-differences approach, combined with intuition from a regression discontinuity approach, to provide causal evidence on the impacts of racial representation in city council in reducing the baseline disparities we document. We find that one additional (narrowly elected) nonwhite¹ member of city council leads to a reduction in the number of Black drivers stopped by officers and - conditional on being stopped - a 2.2-2.9 percentage point reduction in the Black-white disparity in the likelihood of facing a citation or arrest. The reduction in “action taken” among Black drivers appears to be a substitution away from officers issuing citations and towards verbal warnings. Using officer-level data, we show that these effects are primarily driven by changes in individual officer behavior, particularly among those who initially exhibited smaller racial disparities in enforcement.

Our work is linked to two literatures: one on the impacts of racial and ethnic representation in elected office and a second on racial disparities in policing and traffic stops. Several recent papers draw on quasi-experimental methods to provide causal evidence on

how representation of Black and Latino elected officials in local government impacts disparate racial/ethnic outcomes in K-12 education (Kogan et al., 2021; Fischer, 2023) and investment in neighborhoods, as proxied by housing prices (Beach et al., 2024). Our paper uses similar methods to explore whether racial representation impacts policing outcomes. On the one hand, policing is one of the central policy areas under the purview of municipal governments and as such one might expect that similar results - a reduction in disparate outcomes - would materialize in the context of policing. On the other hand, as noted above, racial disparities in policing are notoriously persistent. Moreover, Facchini et al. (2020) document that while the expansion of the franchise to Black Americans following the Voting Rights Act of 1965 impacted arrests made by Sheriff's departments – whose chief officer is *directly* elected –, there was no change in arrests made by municipal police departments – where the chief officer is appointed by city government. They argue that *direct* political accountability was the difference.

Our paper builds on and extends the political economy of policing by identifying an overlooked but important mechanism: legislative oversight through city council representation. Recent work has explored various political channels affecting police behavior: electoral impacts through Trump rallies (Grosjean et al., 2023) and mayoral elections on crime and budgets (Levitt, 1997; de Benedictis-Kessner et al., 2025); officer partisanship effects (Ba et al., 2025; Goncalves and Tuttle, 2024); and institutional mediators like police unions (Mas, 2006). While this literature establishes that politics shapes policing through executive leadership and individual officer ideology, the city council channel remains underexplored. This channel is conceptually distinct from both executive leadership and direct electoral accountability and represents a novel contribution to the growing literature on the political economy of policing.

There has also been a body of work documenting correlational relationships between representation and policing policy and outcomes. For example, Sharp (2014) finds that

cities with Black representation in elected office have a higher share of Black officers; that effect does not, however, translate into changes in racial arrest patterns. Marschall and Shah (2007) find that cities with Black representation in elected office, especially in council, are more likely to have Civilian Review Board and Community Policing initiatives. Christiani et al. (2022) find that a majority Black council is associated with lower search rates across both Black and white drivers conditional on being stopped.

There is substantial *causal* evidence on other factors that may reduce racial disparities in policing, including - for instance - officer demographics (Ba et al., 2021; Hoekstra and Sloan, 2022), and also on documenting racial bias as a driver of disparities in who is stopped and/or searched (Grogger and Ridgeway, 2006; Antonovics and Knight, 2009).

Finally, there is relatively less evidence on racial disparities in the most frequent outcomes of traffic stops (warnings and citations) than on stops themselves and searches. There are some critical exceptions. For example, drawing on data from Massachusetts, Makowsky and Stratmann (2009) find that Hispanic drivers are more likely to be fined, while there is no evidence of a difference in the likelihood of a stopped driver receiving a citation between Black and white drivers. Seguino and Brooks (2021), drawing on data from Vermont, and Baumgartner et al. (2020), drawing on data from North Carolina, on the other hand, both find that Black and Latino drivers are more likely to receive a citation following a traffic stop.² Analyzing high-frequency location data from Lyft rideshare drivers, List et al. (2023) find that Asian, Hispanic, or Black drivers, when moving at identical speeds compared to their white counterparts, are 24 to 33 percent more likely to be pulled over for speeding and face fines that are 23 to 34 percent higher.

The primary contribution of our paper is to present new causal evidence on the question of how racial representation in legislative oversight through city council shapes policing behavior and outcomes, and especially racial disparities therein. We consider an outcome that impacts a large number of individuals: traffic stops and the most typical outcomes of

those traffic stops. Approximately 8 percent of drivers in the United States have contact with law enforcement through a traffic stop in a given year.³ In doing so, we also present new evidence on baseline disparities in these outcomes. Finally, because traffic stops are initiated under a relatively low legal threshold, they involve substantial officer discretion at the initiation stage, making them especially informative for assessing how discretionary policing responds to political and institutional changes.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. Section 2 outlines a simple theoretical framework. Section 3 describes the institutional background, data, and empirical strategy. Section 4 presents the main results, placebo tests, and mechanism analyses. Section 5 concludes.

2 THEORETICAL EXPECTATIONS

Ours is a setting where officers face two decisions. First, they decide whether to stop a driver or not. Then, they decide whether to take punitive action or not – writing a citation and/or arresting the driver vs. giving the driver a verbal warning or taking no action at all. Here, we present a simple framework to illustrate how the potential for discrimination along both margins may drive our empirical results.

To simplify the discussion of these two margins, consider enforcement of speed limits in particular. Officers observe a driver’s speed. Potentially as a function of race, they then decide whether to stop the driver and whether to ticket the driver. In other words, they have a “stop threshold” (ST) and a “ticket threshold” (TT), where - speeds in excess of those thresholds trigger the noted actions - and where the threshold may vary with the race of the driver ($ST_{[race]}$ and $TT_{[race]}$, where $race \in \{w, b\}$). These are both relative to a speed limit (SL).

For illustrative purposes only, Figure 1 depicts a hypothetical scenario where Black and

white drivers' speeds are normally distributed (mean of 55mph and standard deviation of 10mph). The larger distribution depicts white drivers and the smaller distribution depicts Black drivers (capturing differences in population size). In Panel A, there is no racial discrimination in either of these two thresholds – that is, $SL < ST_b = ST_w = 65$ and $TT_b = TT_w = 75$. A key outcome in our paper is the racial difference in the probability of facing punitive action conditional on a stop, here referred to as $P(ticket|stop)$. In this scenario, $P(ticket|stop)$ would be identical for Black and white drivers.

Black drivers might face discrimination on one or both of the two margins depicted. In Panel B, we capture a scenario where officers use the same stop threshold for white and Black drivers, but a lower ticket threshold for Black drivers. In that scenario, $P(ticket|stop)$ is substantially higher for Black drivers than white drivers. In Panel C, we capture a scenario where officers instead use the same ticket threshold for white and Black drivers, but a lower *stop* threshold for Black drivers. In that case, because more Black drivers are stopped who are well below the ticketing threshold, $P(ticket|stop)$ is lower for Black drivers than white drivers. Finally, Panel D captures a scenario where there is discrimination against Black drivers on both dimensions. Here, more Black drivers are stopped *and* more are ticketed. In this particular example, that leads to $P(ticket|stop)$ being higher for Black drivers than white drivers.⁴

If we imagine that increased representation pushes policing from one of the discriminatory scenarios to more equal treatment of drivers (Panel A captures the latter in the extreme), a takeaway is that we might expect the number of Black drivers stopped to remain the same or decrease. Meanwhile, the gap between Black and white drivers in $P(ticket|stop)$ could either decrease (if Panels B and D are baseline) or increase (Panel C is baseline). We note, though, that there is a sufficiently large body of evidence on each of these two margins in isolation to anticipate that Panel D (discrimination in both the likelihood of stopping a driver and in taking action conditional on stopping them) is the scenario that best captures

reality. We would therefore anticipate that increased representation, if it has an effect on reducing discrimination in traffic stops, may move from a scenario that looks like Panel D to a scenario that looks like Panel A.

A move from something like Panel D to more equal treatment of drivers could occur in multiple ways, which is illustrated in Figure 2. Panel A of the figure matches Panel D of the prior figure; it begins with a baseline case where there is discrimination in both stopping and ticketing. If representation leads to a change relative to that baseline, either (1) the thresholds for Black drivers will be deemed too strict and those will be increased to match those of white drivers (Panel C) or (2) the thresholds for Black drivers will be deemed appropriate for all drivers and instead that discrimination had taken the form of leniency towards white drivers, in which case the thresholds for white drivers may come down to match those of Black drivers (Panel B). Of course, it is also possible that both occur and the thresholds meet in the middle (Panel D).

If our main object of interest is the change in the *racial gap* in $P(ticket|stop)$, then moving from Panel A to Panel B or Panel A to C leads to the same conclusion – in Panel A there is a white-Black gap of seven percentage points that is eliminated in both Panels B and C. But, notably, the *way* that the gap is eliminated differs – in Panel B it is through increased ticketing of white drivers (i.e., a stop to leniency for white drivers not offered to Black drivers). In Panel C, it is through a decrease in ticketing of Black drivers (i.e., a recognition that the ticketing thresholds for Black drivers were overly strict).

In short, from these examples, we highlight that a number of outcomes are possible, but which particular outcomes occur highlight the channels through which our results occur. From existing literature, we argue that Panel D of Figure 1 is the most reasonable baseline condition of panels in that figure. Our predictions, then come from Figure 2. In any of the scenarios in that figure, we anticipate a reduction in the white-Black gap in $P(ticket|stop)$. But this may occur either because of an increase in stops and ticketing of white drivers or a

decrease in stops and ticketing of Black drivers, or any combination in between.

3 INSTITUTIONAL DETAILS, METHODS, AND DATA

We use a difference-in-differences specification – within a narrow band of marginal candidates’ margin of victory – comparing outcomes of traffic stops before vs. after a newly elected nonwhite councilmember, compared to the election of a white councilmember.

Our analysis therefore requires data that identify (close) contests between one white and one nonwhite candidate for city council and links that to municipal police agency policing outcomes. We draw on data from two main sources: the “Open Data Policing” platform and North Carolina administrative election records.

3.1 Institutional Details

3.1.1 City Council and Police Department

City councils in the United States have significant influence over local police departments (Stucky, 2005). They are typically responsible for approving the budgets of all city departments, including that of the police. This authority over budgeting enables them to directly affect the police department’s scale, focus, and operations by designating funds for certain projects, staffing, equipment, and training initiatives. Furthermore, city councils may pass ordinances and resolutions that set policies for the police department to follow. These can include regulations on policing practices, community policing initiatives, and measures aimed at increasing transparency and accountability. In certain cities, the council also has the power to appoint the police chief or other high-ranking officials within the department, thus having a substantial impact on its leadership and strategic direction. Additionally, city councils have the capability to oversee the police through hearings and inquiries into their practices, response to incidents, and interaction with the community, potentially leading to

suggestions or compulsory changes within the department.

There is ample anecdotal evidence to point to that councils, including those in North Carolina (the setting for our study), have paid attention to traffic stops in recent years. In 2024, the city council in Fayetteville, NC considered – but ultimately voted down – a measure proposed by one councilmember aimed to “address racial disparities in the stops and searches”; one councilmember who opposed the measure argued that they should not be in the business of “trying to tell the police how to police”.⁵ In Asheville, NC in 2017, the Council asked the police chief to examine data and racial disparities in traffic stops and return with a report, with one councilmember calling the disparities in stops “an emergency”.⁶ In 2015, “[u]rged by the Greensboro City Council to take swift, decisive action”, the Greensboro, NC police department halted traffic stops for minor equipment violations altogether, with the aim of reducing racial disparities.⁷ These anecdotes highlight two key mechanisms through which council may impact racial disparities: (1) direct legislation and/or (2) pressure on and monitoring of the Police Department, through the Police Chief.

Formal adoption of policy on a council is made through majority rule, but as the anecdotes above highlight, a single member can have an influence on policy that is made, as any councilmember may put forth a measure for consideration. A single member can of course also have an impact on policy through coalition formation, which is aided by the relatively small size of councils. This is relevant to our paper, as we consider the impacts of the election of one additional nonwhite (usually Black) candidate. Notably, there is existing empirical evidence that a single additional underrepresented candidate can have a significant impact on policy outcomes in local boards (Beach et al., 2024; Kogan et al., 2021).

3.1.2 Municipal Council Elections

In this subsection, we outline relevant institutional details of municipal council elections in North Carolina to provide context for our discussion of methods. Many municipal council contests in the state aim to fill multiple seats. For instance, two seats might be open; in such a case, the top two vote-getters would be elected to office. This is important for our empirical design; we focus on the “marginal candidates”: the lowest ranked winner and the highest ranked loser. If filling two seats, that would be the second and third ranked candidates. In such a case, a narrow victory of the first-ranked candidate over the second-ranked candidate would have no impact on council composition – both would join the council. Multiple seats are filled in a single contest when elections are on an at-large, rather than district-based, basis. In North Carolina, that is true of roughly 86 percent of municipalities. The modal and (roughly) average and median number of members in a municipal council is five. Members serve two- or, more frequently, four-year terms.⁸ Nearly all contests are non-partisan.

3.2 Data

3.2.1 Policing Data

As described on their website, “Open Data Policing aggregates, visualizes, and publishes public records related to all known traffic stops to have occurred in North Carolina since Jan 01, 2002. Data is available for most North Carolina departments and officers serving populations greater than 10,000.” That last note is important as it is one of two reasons, revisited shortly, as to why we do not observe the universe of municipalities in the state.

The data report, for each traffic stop, the race, gender, and age of the individual stopped; the agency of the officer who made the stop; the date and time of the stop; the reason for the stop; and the action taken as a result of the stop. The data also include an anonymized identifier for the officer who made the stop, which will allow for inclusion of officer fixed

effects in our analysis.⁹ There are ten distinct reasons listed for stops. The three most common, accounting for over two-thirds of stops are: Speed Limit Violation, Vehicle Regulatory Violation, and Vehicle Equipment Violation.¹⁰ There are five possible actions (listed here in order of frequency): Citation Issued, Verbal Warning, Written Warning, No Action Taken, and On-View Arrest. “Citation Issued” and “Verbal Warning” are the most common, together accounting for more than two-thirds of outcomes. Arrests are relatively rare (less than five percent). Appendix Table A.1 reports frequencies of stops, stop purpose, and resulting action, overall and by race. For our analysis, we create a dummy variable – called “Action Taken” – equal to one if the outcome is “Citation Issued” or “On-View Arrest” and equal to zero otherwise. That is our main outcome variable.

Because our focus is on city councils, we restrict the Open Policing data to stops made by officers from municipal police agencies, which city councils have jurisdiction over; in other words, we drop stops by officers from Sheriff’s Departments, State Highway Patrol, and college/university police agencies.

In instances with multiple passengers, the data lists the race/ethnicity of each passenger, but without identifying the race/ethnicity of the driver in particular. To simplify our analysis and avoid ambiguity on this front, we restrict our data to observations where only a single race/ethnicity (and therefore single driver) is listed. We further restrict our data to only white, Black, or Latino individuals. Other race/ethnic groups are listed in the data, but form a very small share of the overall sample. Black drivers account for roughly 42% of stops in our sample (nearly twice the Black share of the population), and white drivers account for 49%¹¹.

Finally, it is worth noting that whether a traffic stop escalates to a violent or fatal encounter with the police is also a critically important piece in documenting and understanding racism in policing (Knox et al., 2020); those outcomes, however, are not in our dataset and as such are not explored in this study.

3.2.2 Elections Data

Our elections data are administrative records obtained from the North Carolina State Board of Elections website. We draw on three forms of administrative elections data: election returns, candidate filing, and voter registration files.

The election returns data, most obviously, are essential for identifying when and where close city council elections occurred. They report candidate-level vote totals for every election in North Carolina, with candidates' names and the office they run for. We extract from these the candidates for city council from the years 2011-2019.

The candidate-level data does not include any personal data on the candidates, namely: race, gender, or partisan affiliation. Thus, we cannot immediately use the elections data to identify close elections *between white and nonwhite candidates*. Instead, we turn to voter registration files to fill in those details. In North Carolina, voter registration files include voters' race, ethnicity, gender, partisan affiliation, address, and more. One solution to attaching demographic information to our city council candidates would be to attempt to match council candidates from election returns to voter files by candidate name and city. A drawback of that approach is that candidates with more common names may match to multiple individuals in the voter registration files within a given city. To overcome that, we draw in a third dataset: candidate filings data. These data report the universe of candidates for public office in North Carolina each election year and the home address of these candidates. We therefore first match candidates by name and city to the candidate filings data to uncover their address. We can then match candidates by name and some more specific geography (we use zipcode) to the election returns, to minimize duplicate matches. It is worth noting that we do still fail to match some candidates; this can happen, for instance, as a result of discrepancies in how candidates' names are spelled in elections return data vs. the voter files (e.g., "Robert Zimmerman" vs. "R. Allen Zimmerman" or

“Bob Zimmerman”).

The candidate filings data are also important to our data construction, as they include some additional detail on the election itself – e.g., the number of seats being filled.¹²

3.2.3 *Analysis Data*

The resulting elections dataset includes the set of city council elections from 2011 to 2019 where one of the two marginal candidates (last winner and first loser) was white and the other not white¹³. We identify 207 unique contests in 149 unique municipalities that fit this description. Amongst “close” contests (a margin of victory of less than ten percentage points), we observe 99 unique contests in 84 unique municipalities. Merging the elections data with the policing data, we lose some municipalities that do not manage their own police agencies (contracting to neighboring municipalities or under the jurisdiction of the sheriff’s department) and also the small number of municipalities not covered by the policing data. That results in 60 total municipalities and 83 total elections, and 31 municipalities and 38 elections in contests decided by ten percentage points or less.

In merging election data with policing data, we create a panel around each election. Specifically, for each election, we include four years of policing data before the new councilmembers take office and the four years after; however, due to ambiguity in when councilmembers take office and due to shifts in police spending and policy in elections years (McCrary, 2002; Baicker and Jacobson, 2007), we omit policing data from election years.

3.3 **Methods**

Our main methodological approach is a difference-in-differences design, paired with the intuition of a regression discontinuity approach. We do not use a more typical cross-sectional regression discontinuity design due to the relatively low number of municipalities and elections in our final dataset. The canonical close-elections regression discontinuity design

relies solely on post-election variation and fits lines to candidates' margins of victory on either side of the victory threshold; doing so ideally leverages a large number of observations on either side of the cutoff to reliably fit lines to the data and identify the discontinuity at the cutoff. A difference-in-differences approach, comparing averages before and after an event, imposes less structure and as such is a better fit for a scenario with a smaller number of observations on either side of the cutoff.

As such, noting again that we construct a panel around each relevant election event, we take advantage of observing both pre- and post- election observations of each agency. Our difference-in-differences setup therefore compares changes in policing outcomes before vs. after an election between a white and nonwhite candidate in municipalities where the nonwhite candidate won (relative to cities where the nonwhite candidate did not).

We do, however, still draw on the regression discontinuity intuition that outcomes in narrowly contested elections are more plausibly exogenous than in the full range of contests. As such, while our estimating equation is a difference-in-differences specification, we restrict our attention to relatively narrowly decided contests (with margins of victory of less than 10 percentage points).¹⁴

The simplest representation of our estimating equation is:

$$\text{Action Taken}_{eit} = \beta_1 (\text{Non-White Win}_i \times \text{Post}_t) + \beta_2 \text{Post}_t + \beta_3 \text{Non-White Win}_i + \theta_i + \tau_t + \epsilon_{eit} \quad (1)$$

In the equation, e indexes police encounters, i indexes police agencies or municipalities, and t indexes time periods (relative to the election year). $\text{Action Taken}_{eit}$ is a dummy variable indicating whether a police encounter resulted in an “action taken” as defined above (citation or arrest). We include municipality-election (θ_i) and year fixed effects (τ_t). β_1 is our coefficient of interest and captures the impact of a nonwhite candidate winning

on police behavior. “Non-White Win” itself is absorbed into municipality-election specific fixed effects. Because “post” is defined with respect to election timing, it is not absorbed into (calendar) year fixed effects.

For added robustness, we do also present results where we interact “post”, “nonwhite win”, and the interaction of those variables with the nonwhite candidate’s margin of victory (or loss), pushing the specification closer to a regression discontinuity, but still within the panel framework. In those specifications, as with standard regression discontinuity, identification occurs at the margin – that is, for cities with the closest election outcomes. In the results section, we refer to this as our RD-DiD approach.

Of course, the above equation would only estimate overall impacts of a new nonwhite councilmember on police behavior. Our interest in this paper is whether there is a differential impact on encounters involving Black and Latino drivers. As such, for our main specifications, we instead fully interact both $\text{Non-White Win}_i \times \text{Post}_t$ and Post_t with dummy variables indicating whether the driver was Black.

In our main specifications, in addition to municipality-by-election and year fixed effects, we also include fixed effects for hour of the stop and month. Additional specifications add driver demographics (age and sex), stop purpose fixed effects, and officer fixed effects.

Only the richest specification includes officer fixed effects. A comparison of specifications with vs. without officer fixed effects will help us consider the mechanism driving our results. If any results that we observe in specification without officer fixed effects go away with the inclusion of officer fixed effects, that would indicate that effects are not occurring *within* officers and instead may be driven by shifts in composition of a police force. If effects survive in specifications with officer fixed effects, that suggests that the impacts of representation in city council impacts individual officer behavior.

Throughout, standard errors are clustered at the agency level.

We note that it is theoretically possible for a non-white candidate to win in the narrow

elections that we study and for that to *not* impact the racial composition of the council. That might happen because there are often multiple simultaneous races for the same city council. If the narrow election of a nonwhite candidate in the marginal slot more frequently happened when nonwhite candidates elsewhere on the ballot (or in other seats) are losing, there may be no net change in council composition. To confirm that our “treatment” is associated with a change in actual racial composition on the council, we run a simple version of our main specification where we take racial composition of the council as the outcome. To do so, we construct the racial composition by council term (two year period). We include one council term before and one after the relevant election and assess how racial composition changes with a narrow nonwhite victory. Results are reported in Table 1 and generally document a statistically significant increase in Black councilmember presence associated with our treatment.¹⁵

Because our design incorporates a regression discontinuity component, Appendix Table A.2 and Table A.12 report balance tests for a set of covariates at the 10 percent vote-share cutoff. We find that the narrow election of a nonwhite candidate is unrelated to candidate gender, the share of nonwhite residents in the local population, the share of Democratic voters, or pre-election local population and income. Unsurprisingly, given the correlation between race and partisan affiliation, the narrow election of a nonwhite candidate is associated with a higher likelihood of Democratic victory. Given this, we check whether our results are driven by the democratic councilmember effect. Table A.5 in the Appendix shows that even after including a series of interaction terms with the party affiliation dummy, electing a nonwhite councilmember can significantly account for the narrowing of the Black-white gap in actions taken.

4 RESULTS

4.1 Descriptive Analysis: Baseline Racial/Ethnic Gaps in Outcomes of Traffic Stops

Before turning to our analysis of the impacts of city council representation, we begin by examining the overall racial disparities in policing behaviors, especially, the action taken after a stop.

Table 2 presents the baseline racial disparities in the actions taken following stops for Black drivers. Within the whole dataset of stops (that is, without restricting to our close elections sample), Black drivers are approximately 1.4 to 3.8 percentage points more likely to have actions taken against them after a stop compared to white drivers after controlling the core fixed effects¹⁶. The coefficients vary based on the inclusion of various fixed effects, the demographics of the drivers, and the specific data sample that we used. Our preferred estimate, from the close-election sample (column 6), indicates a 2.7 percentage point change, corresponding to about a 5% shift relative to the pre-election mean.¹⁷

4.2 Effects of Nonwhite Council Representation

In light of the substantial racial and ethnic gaps in stops and “Action Taken” after a stop, we now examine whether increased representation of nonwhite councilmembers can help reduce this disparity.

4.2.1 *Impacts on Composition of Drivers Stopped*

Table 3 shows the effect of a victory by nonwhite council candidates on the number of stops executed by police officers. We conduct analysis using data collapsed at the officer level. After the election of nonwhite councilmembers, there is no significant change in the overall number of stops. However, police officers made fewer stops involving Black drivers. Our preferred estimate in Table 3 is Column 4 (with officer-level fixed effects), which suggests a

16.6% decrease in the number of stops made against Black drivers. On average, each officer stops 10 fewer Black motorists after a narrow victory of a nonwhite councilmember.

4.2.2 *Impacts on Outcomes of Traffic Stops*

Understanding that having a nonwhite councilmember reduces the number of stops involving Black drivers, we now turn to an analysis on outcomes of these stops. Table 4 displays the differential effects of a victory by a nonwhite council candidate on the actions taken post-stop for Black drivers, as compared to the baseline group of white drivers. As a reminder, “action taken” here is defined as the driver receiving a citation or being arrested as opposed to receiving a warning or even no action.

The Black-white gap in likelihood of action taken shrinks by 2.2 to 2.9 percentage points following the election of a nonwhite councilmember – large effects relative to the baseline gaps documented in Table 2. The estimates in Columns 2 and 3 (without vs. with officer fixed effects) are quite close; that suggests that the main effects are derived from individual officer behavioral changes, rather than shifts in the composition of the force via hiring and firing. In the appendix, we test for robustness across different bandwidths. Appendix Table A.3 shows that the estimates are quite similar across a narrower or wider bandwidth. Column 4 of Table 4 reports the results of the combined RD-DiD approach, where all DiD variables are further interacted with candidates’ margin of victory. The result for the Black-white gap is remarkably similar to Column 3.

Figure 3 employs an event study approach to our data. We modify a version of equation (1), substituting the “Post” indicator with a series of variables indicating the number of years before/after the election the action was taken following a stop. Panel (a) reports Black-white gaps; Panels (b) adopt a similar event study approach to the RD-DiD specifications – where all relevant variables are interacted with margin of victory such that the main variables are identified only for very close elections.

In short, across the four panels, we find no evidence of pre-trends. The post-period results largely mirror what we have already documented: Black-white gaps decline after the election of a Black candidate. Appendix Figures A.1 further report event studies for additional bandwidths and again lead to the same conclusions.

In councilmember elections between nonwhite and white candidates in North Carolina, 39.8% of the contests are between Republican and Democratic candidates. Given this, we check whether our results are driven by the democratic councilmember effect. We incorporated an interaction between the party affiliation dummy and the election time dummy into equation 1. Table A.5 in the Appendix shows that even after including a series of interaction terms with the party affiliation dummy, electing a nonwhite councilmember can significantly account for the narrowing of the Black-white gap in actions taken. While a councilmember's party affiliation may influence actions taken against all drivers, it has no significant impact on Black-white gaps in action taken. That result is especially important in light of the fact that partisan affiliation was the one dimension that we (unsurprisingly) observed a failure of covariate balance in Appendix Table A.2.

To gain a deeper understanding of the decrease in racial disparities in actions taken post-stop, we examined all five possible outcomes following stops, rather than simply grouping outcomes into "action taken" or not. Results are reported in Table 6. Most notably, we find that the reduction in "action taken" amongst Black drivers appears to be a substitution away from officers issuing citations and towards verbal warnings.

It is worth considering our impacts on outcomes of traffic stops in light of our prior finding that fewer Black drivers are stopped with more council representation. If the reduction in Black drivers stopped consists primarily of drivers with no clear violation, an especially minor violation, or great uncertainty about the potential for a violation, then – in the absence of a change in officer behavior after stopping a driver – we might expect an *increase* in negative outcomes for Black drivers conditional on being stopped. That

suggests that our estimates in this section are an *underestimate* of the true effect that we would detect if we could more directly control for officers' perception of drivers' potential violations. We find that Black drivers are less likely to experience material consequences of being stopped compared to white drivers; these effects are likely even more negative.

We also re-estimate our main specification using group-specific outcomes. Specifically, we disaggregate our main analysis by driver race and estimate how nonwhite council candidate win on action taken separately for each racial group.

Appendix Table A.6 shows that a nonwhite council candidate win has no statistically significant effect on the action-taken rate for the full sample or for Black, Hispanic, or White drivers. However, the point estimate for Black drivers (Column 2) is close to zero, whereas the corresponding estimate for White drivers (Column 4) is notably larger in magnitude. This pattern is consistent with our theoretical framework (Section 2). Ultimately, our paper focuses on disparities rather than levels: racial disparity is captured by differential treatment of Black and White drivers.

Finally, in light of our finding that there are *within-officer* shifts in policing behavior (per the models with officer fixed effects), we adopt a different approach to assess *which* officers are changing their behavior. Specifically, we regress the “action taken” dummy on a vector of controls (year, month, time of day, purpose of stop, and driver gender) but also on a set of officer-by-driver race-by-pre/post election fixed effects. That yields one fixed effect per officer in the pre and post period for each race group that they stopped: δ_{rti} , where r is race, t is pre or post, i indexes officers. That allows us to construct - both before and after a relevant election - the *gap* in an officer's general propensity to “take action” after stopping a Black driver relative to white driver. For instance, post-election, we construct the Black-white gap in likelihood of taking action (conditional on all controls previously noted) as $\delta_{Black,post,i} - \delta_{white,post,i}$ and similarly construct a gap for the pre-period as: $\delta_{Black,pre,i} - \delta_{white,pre,i}$. The latter of these allows us to identify officers who had higher vs.

lower propensities to “take action” after stopping a Black driver (relative to white driver) prior to a relevant election happening, which we can in turn use to ask whether it was the officers with a history of differential treatment of drivers by race that changed their behavior the most.

Table 5 presents estimates taking the “Black-white gap” in likelihood of taking an action as our outcome. The estimates are at the office-by-time period (pre vs. post) level. Column 1 simply documents that, under this different approach, we reach a similar conclusion – there is a reduction in the gap in likelihood of taking an action against a Black driver relative to white driver following the election of a nonwhite councilmember. More interestingly, in Columns 2 and 3, we test whether that result differs based on an officer’s pre-existing “Black-white gap” measure. Ultimately, we find that it is officers with *lower* initial Black-white gaps who primarily drive the results.

4.2.3 *Impact on Crime Reports and Arrests*

Crime and arrest outcomes are also central to understanding the broader impacts of minority representation in city council on the criminal justice outcomes. We use annual Uniform Crime Reporting (UCR) data to examine whether city council elections affect crime reports and arrest outcomes.

Applying our main empirical framework, we find no statistically significant effects on overall reported offenses, or property offenses (Appendix Table A.7), nor on arrests (Appendix Table A.8) or the share of Black individuals in arrests (Appendix Table A.9). Two estimates are exceptions. Reported violent offenses decline (Appendix Table A.7, Column 4), as does the Black share of arrests for violent offenses (Appendix Table A.9, Column 3), although both estimates are only statistically significant at the 10 percent level.

With these two exceptions, the estimates are null and are consistent with our earlier findings of no effect on arrest-related action taken during traffic stops. One plausible

explanation is that traffic stops are governed by a lower legal threshold of reasonable suspicion, which allows for more police discretion and responsiveness to local political dynamics. In contrast, arrests and other criminal justice actions require probable cause, a higher evidentiary standard that leaves less room for discretionary change in response to city council turnover. These differences help explain why we observe effects are concentrate in traffic stops rather than in arrests or reported crime rates. The two marginally significant estimates are negative and therefore point in the same direction as our main results; given the number of coefficients estimated across Appendix Tables A.7–A.9, however, we treat them as suggestive rather than as independent evidence.

4.2.4 Placebo Tests and Heterogeneity

To ensure that our estimated effects are driven by increases in racial representation rather than by political turnover, we conduct a placebo test in which both marginal candidates are white. Specifically, we identify elections in which the two marginal candidates consist of one incumbent and one challenger, both of whom are white. There are 65 such elections in our sample. Using our main empirical specification, we estimate the effect of a white challenger narrowly winning the election. The results, reported in Appendix Table A.10, show no change in racial disparities in police action taken. This placebo test supports the interpretation that the effects we document are attributable to racial representation rather than to political turnover alone.

We extend the baseline specification by interacting the treatment with measures of local political context to examine heterogeneity across partisan environments. Because municipal-level Democratic vote share is unavailable, we proxy political context using county-level Democratic vote share. Appendix Table A.11 shows that racial disparities in police stop action-taken outcomes decline in both high–Democratic-share and low–Democratic-share areas,¹⁸ indicating that the effect of non-White council represen-

tation on policing disparities is not concentrated in a particular partisan context.

We additionally conduct balance tests using the analysis sample of cities with close elections, comparing pre-treatment demographic characteristics between treated and control cities. Appendix Table A.12 shows no statistically significant differences in total population, Black population, the share of Black residents, or median income.

4.3 Mechanism

To explore the mechanism of why minority representation in city council affects racial disparities in policing, we collect additional data from multiple sources about council meetings and police chief appointments.

We retrieved LocalView corpus of city council meeting transcripts. Using our main empirical design and the meeting-level information, we examine whether narrowly decided elections affect how frequently city councils discuss policing- and equity-related issues.

To operationalize these topics, we construct two groups of keywords from the meeting transcripts. The first group captures general policing discussions using terms such as “police,” “policing,” and “cop”; traffic-stop–related terms such as “police stop,” “stop and frisk,” and “traffic stop”; and police-specific accountability terms such as “body(-worn) camera.” The second group captures race and justice–related discussions using terms such as “Hispanic,” “Latino,” “Latina,” “African American,” “racial,” “racism,” “equity,” “equality,” “discrimination,” “justice,” and “fair.”

As shown in Panel A of Appendix Table A.13, our estimates indicate that following a narrow minority council victory, city councils tend to discuss policing-related issues more frequently. The close-election sample contains only seven elections, however, and the resulting standard errors are unlikely to be reliable; we therefore also report estimates using all elections contested between white and nonwhite candidates (Panel B). In that wider sample, the effects on policing-related topics (Columns 2–4) are not statistically

significant, the coefficients are consistently positive, as they are in the close-election sample. Similarly, the results in Columns 5–6 show that discussions of race- and justice-related topics also increase after minority council victories. Column 1, which aggregates all keywords, shows a positive but insignificant effect. A PPML (Poisson Pseudo Maximum Likelihood) specification yield consistent results.

Overall, while the effects are modest in size and precision, the consistent positive pattern suggests that minority representation increases council attention to policing and equity issues, reinforcing our interpretation that legislative oversight and deliberation are key mechanisms linking minority representation to policing outcomes.

To examine whether changes in council racial representation are associated with leadership transitions within police departments, we use newly collected data from de Benedictis-Kessner et al. (2025) about police chiefs demographics. Our results in Appendix Table A.14 show that the narrow election of a minority councilmember increases the police chief turnover rate, an effect significant at the 10 percent level; the corresponding estimate is smaller and not statistically significant when all elections are included (Columns 3). It does not increase the probability of appointing a nonwhite chief or a female chief. The nonwhite-chief coefficient cannot be estimated in the close-election sample, which contains six elections; estimated on all elections it is negative and statistically insignificant.

These findings are consistent with a mechanism in which the behavior of the incumbent police force changes, rather than the entry of a new, more diverse, and less discriminatory police force. The latter would likely be associated with increases in police budgets and a higher share of minority officers, which we do not observe. Instead, the evidence suggests that changes occur through increased council attention to policing and justice-related issues and/or through leadership turnover within police departments.

5 CONCLUSION

From prior research, there is ample evidence of racial/ethnic disparities in the likelihood of being stopped in traffic and also in the likelihood of being searched conditional on being stopped (Baumgartner et al., 2017). Disparities in the likelihood of being searched are especially problematic in that they may open a path to further disparities in broader contact with the criminal justice system, or, tragically, violent or fatal encounters with the police. And, yet, per Baumgartner et al. (2017) searches occur for roughly three percent of traffic stops. A much larger share of stops result in some form of consequence based on the purported reason for the stop: e.g., a verbal warning or a citation. These outcomes are the focus of our paper.

Even for “routine” stops that do not end in a search or violence, any disparities in the likelihood of being issued a citation are further magnified by the different downstream impacts this may have on different groups in a broader system of racism. Baumgartner et al. (2018) and Goffman (2014) note how a traffic encounter for individuals, for instance, with prior contact with the criminal justice system can lead to job loss, eviction, or jail time. As such, it is critical to document the scope of disparities in traffic citations – especially in light of potential disparate downstream impacts – and understand paths towards reducing them. Our paper documents one such path: greater racial representation in elected office.

Specifically, we draw on administrative data on the outcomes of traffic stops from municipal police agencies in North Carolina during the 2010s. We first document large baseline disparities. Black drivers are 1.4 to 3.8 percentage points more likely to suffer a material consequence of the stop (citation or, less frequently, arrest), depending on the set of controls included.

We then turn our attention to our main focus: can the political process play a role in reducing these gaps? Specifically, because municipal police agencies are supervised

by municipal government (mayors and city councils), we ask: does increased nonwhite representation on a city council impact racial/ethnic gaps in traffic stops and traffic stop outcomes? With respect to the Black-white disparities in traffic stops, the answer is a very clear “yes”. The reduction in the Black-white gap in the likelihood that a traffic stop results in a citation or arrest is almost large enough to eliminate the estimated baseline gap altogether. In particular, conditional on a wide array of controls, Black drivers are less likely to receive a citation and more likely to instead receive a “verbal warning”. These effects could occur either through shifts in the composition of the police force or via changes in individual officer-level behavior. We find evidence that results are largely driven by the latter.

NOTES

¹Among all candidates in the dataset, 97% are Black and white. Therefore, this project focuses specifically on racial disparities between Black and white drivers.

²Also, see Graham and Makowsky (2021) for a review of work on local government's financial reliance on criminal justice revenue and how that shapes outcomes like traffic citations.

³See <https://bjs.ojp.gov/content/pub/pdf/cbpp18st.pdf>.

⁴For this particular panel, whether $P(ticket|stop)$ is higher for Black or white drivers depends on the degree of discrimination on both margins.

⁵<https://www.cityviewnc.com/stories/council-votes-against-having-committee-review-traffic-stop-disparity-solutions,74058>

⁶<https://www.citizen-times.com/story/news/local/2017/04/25/race-issues-around-asheville-traffic-stops-urgent-council-members-say/100907106/>

⁷<https://www.providencejournal.com/story/news/state/2015/11/23/data-black-males-more-likely/32967218007/>

⁸Many of these details are drawn from University of North Carolina School of Government's database on municipal form in North Carolina: <https://www.sog.unc.edu/forms-of-government-paged> .

⁹We do not observe any demographic information about the officers.

¹⁰The remaining reasons, in order of frequency, are: Investigation, Seat Belt Violation, Safe Movement Violation, Stop Light/Sign Violation, Other Motor Vehicle Violation, Checkpoint, and Driving While Impaired.

¹¹Latino drivers account for 9% (close to their share of the population)

¹²That is important because the elections data does not include an indicator variable for being elected in all years in our sample. In city council elections, often, multiple seats are being filled simultaneously, with the top N vote-getters filling the N seats. Thus, in the absence of an indicator for winning, knowing the number of seats being filled is critical for us to identify the "marginal" candidates.

¹³Among all candidates in the dataset, 18% are Black and 79% are white. Therefore, this project focuses specifically on racial disparities between Black and white drivers.

¹⁴A bandwidth of 10 percentage points was determined by collapsing the data to one observation per agency, measure post vs. pre changes in residualized outcomes (residualizing out the main set of fixed effects and controls used in our analysis). We then use the Calonico et al. (2014) method, positing a polynomial of degree zero (to match that our analysis does not fit lines to either side of the cutoff), to identify the optimal bandwidth. Our appendix documents robustness to other bandwidths.

¹⁵The exercise reported in Table 1 draws on a smaller sample than our main sample, both because it is less granular in time (two year periods, with only one pre and one post period) but - more importantly - because to construct “pre-” observations of council composition means that we cannot use some of the earliest elections in our data. That is driven by the fact that our only method of constructing council composition is to look to winners of even earlier elections. Specifically, to identify the “pre-” composition in a council that has staggered two year terms, we must go to the elections two years prior and four years prior, identify winners from those elections and calculate race shares. That means that we can only use “treating” elections that are more than four years after the start of our elections sample period. As such, we expand to wider bandwidths than we do in the main analysis.

¹⁶They include month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects.

¹⁷Appendix Table A.4 shows that, in control municipalities, about half of all stops result in an enforcement action. 2.7 percentage point change is around 5%.

¹⁸Counties are classified as high or low Democratic share based on the median county-level Democratic vote share of 63.2 percent.

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FIGURE CAPTIONS

Figure 1. Theoretical Scenarios Capturing Officers' Decision to Stop and Cite Drivers

Figure 2. Theoretical Scenarios Capturing Officers' Decision to Stop and Cite Drivers

Figure 3. Event Studies: Action Taken, Black Drivers

Table 1: Narrow Nonwhite Candidate Victory and Council Composition (Share of Black), Different Bandwidths

VARIABLES	(1) Share Black	(2) Share Black	(3) Share Black
Post X NW Win	0.305* (0.149)	0.201** (0.087)	0.187** (0.077)
Observations	38	70	98
R-squared	0.668	0.743	0.762
Bandwidth	0.10	0.25	0.5

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** $p < 0.01$, ** $p < 0.05$, * $p < 0.1$

Notes: Unit of observation is council-term, with one observation before a relevant election and one observation after. Outcome variable is share of candidates (with known race/eth.) who are Black. Election fixed effects are included, as is a simple “Post” dummy. (Not shown.) Each column adopts a different bandwidth.

Table 2: Baseline Disparities in Action Taken After Stop, Relative to White Drivers

VARIABLES	(1) Action Taken	(2) Action Taken	(3) Action Taken	(4) Action Taken	(5) Action Taken	(6) Action Taken
Black Driver	0.014** (0.007)	0.028*** (0.005)	0.021*** (0.005)	0.028*** (0.003)	0.038*** (0.009)	0.027*** (0.003)
Observations	5,822,004	5,822,004	5,766,999	5,755,486	4,507,862	1,168,763
R-squared	0.073	0.144	0.156	0.269	0.266	0.288
Core FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Purpose FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Election Sample					Yes	Yes
Close Election Samp.						Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: “Core FEs” includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. “Stop Purpose FEs” include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. “Driver Demos.” includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table 3: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Officer-level Stops

VARIABLES	(1) Total Stops	(2) Total Stops	(3) Black Stops	(4) Black Stops
Post X NW Win	-12.712 (9.104)	-8.224 (6.873)	-8.868* (4.503)	-10.168** (4.218)
Observations	20,901	17,669	20,901	17,669
R-squared	0.029	0.683	0.061	0.673
Officer FE's	No	Yes	No	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: Average number of total stops at officer level in estimation sample is 61.

Table 4: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Post-Stop Police Action

VARIABLES	(1) Action Taken	(2) Action Taken	(3) Action Taken	(4) Action Taken
Post X NW Win	0.054 (0.032)	0.030 (0.029)	0.009 (0.025)	-0.035 (0.040)
Post X NW Win X Black Driver	-0.027** (0.013)	-0.029** (0.011)	-0.023*** (0.005)	-0.022*** (0.006)
Observations	1,181,398	1,170,449	1,168,763	1,168,763
R-squared	0.070	0.153	0.289	0.289
Core FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FE's	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FE's	No	No	Yes	Yes
Method	DiD	DiD	DiD	RD-DiD

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: "Action Taken" is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation or arrested; equal to zero if no action is taken or drivers receive a verbal or written warning. "Core FEs" includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. "Stop Purpose FEs" include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. "Driver Demos." includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table 5: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Post-Stop Police Action, value added method

VARIABLES	(1) BW gap	(2) BW gap	(3) BW gap
Post X NW Win	-0.019* (0.011)	-0.062** (0.025)	-0.063** (0.026)
Post X NW Win X High BW gap		0.096* (0.055)	
Post X NW Win X Positive BW gap			0.089 (0.054)
Observations	3,976	3,762	3,762
R-squared	0.759	0.756	0.754
Lin. Comb.	0.00328	0.0339	0.0263
p-val.	0.590		
p-value		0.325	0.403

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: “Action Taken” is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation or arrested; equal to zero if no action is taken or drivers receive a verbal or written warning. “Core FEs” includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. “Stop Purpose FEs” include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. “Driver Demos.” includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table 6: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Post-Stop Police Action, All Possible Outcomes

VARIABLES	(1) None	(2) Verbal Warn.	(3) Written Warn.	(4) Citation	(5) Arrest
Post X NW Win	0.003 (0.003)	-0.008 (0.014)	-0.004 (0.021)	0.010 (0.023)	-0.002 (0.002)
Post X NW Win X Black Driver	0.001 (0.002)	0.031*** (0.010)	-0.009 (0.009)	-0.024*** (0.006)	0.001 (0.002)
Observations	1,168,763	1,168,763	1,168,763	1,168,763	1,168,763
R-squared	0.163	0.344	0.240	0.299	0.084
Core FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: Each column takes a dummy variable as outcome, indicated by the column header. “Core FEs” includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. “Stop Purpose FEs” include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. “Driver Demos.” includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Figure 1: Theoretical Scenarios Capturing Officers' Decision to Stop and Cite Drivers (I)

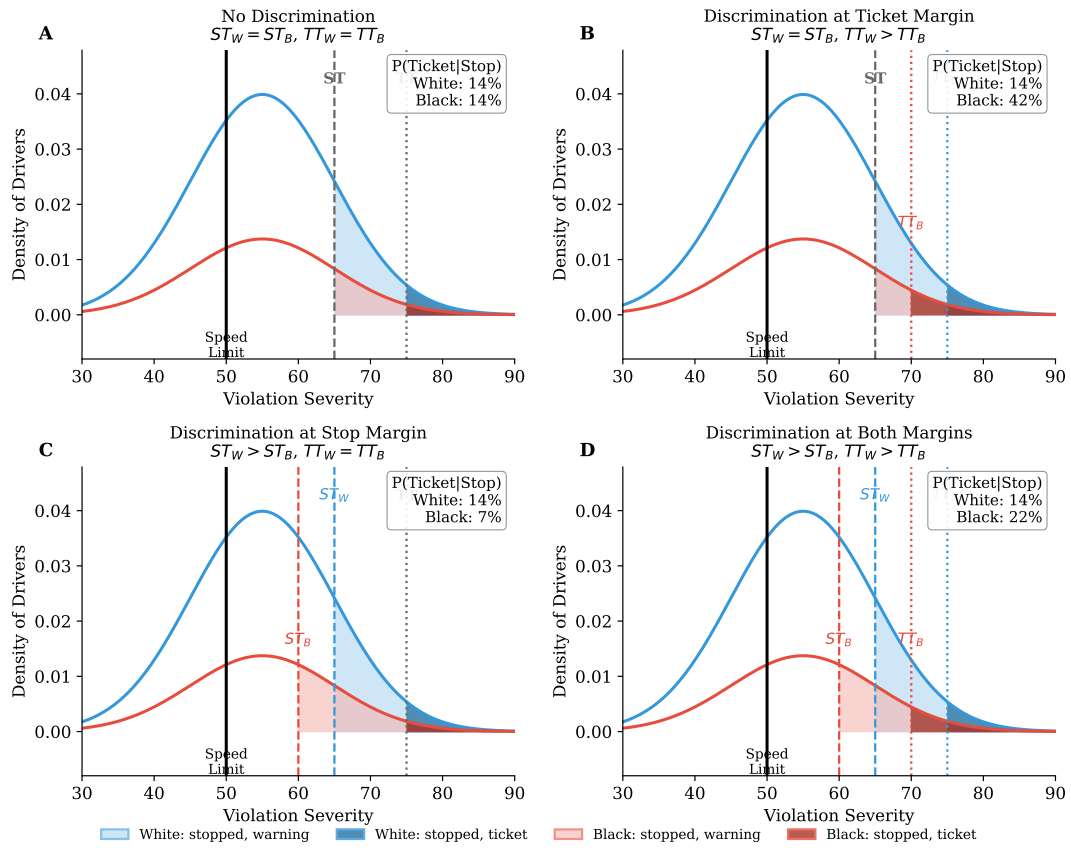


Figure 2: Theoretical Scenarios Capturing Officers' Decision to Stop and Cite Drivers (II)

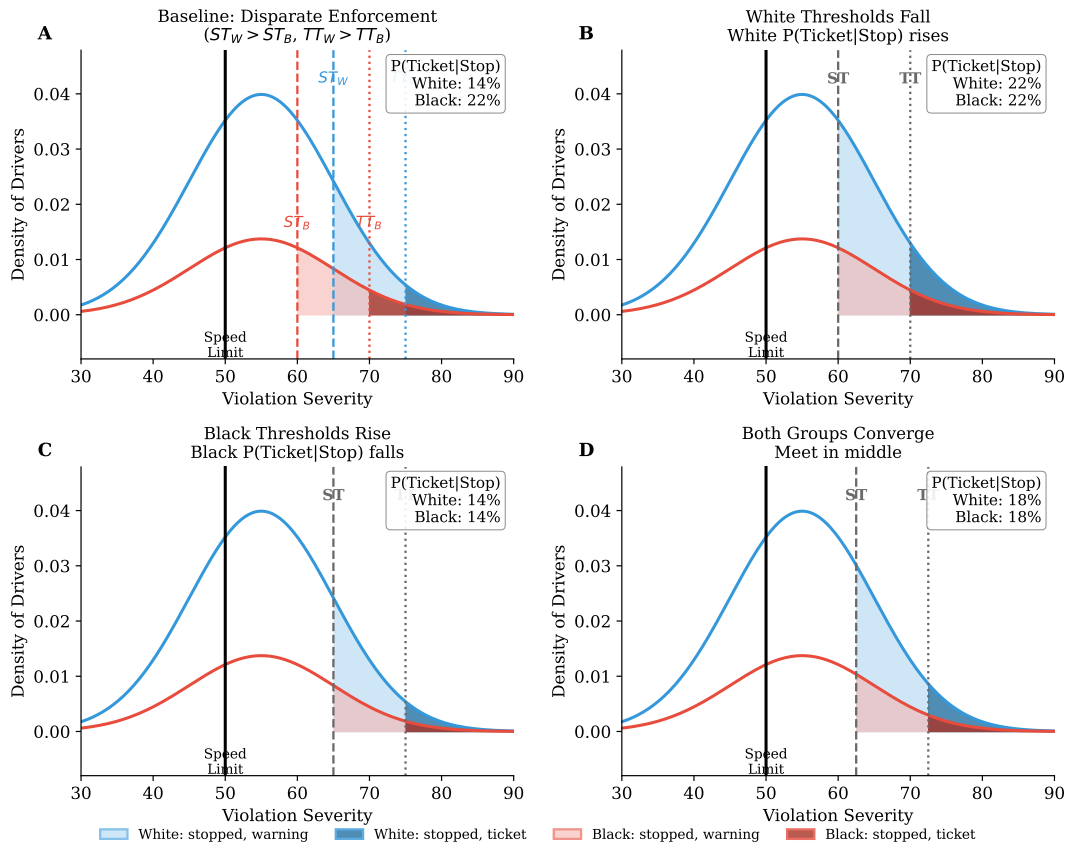
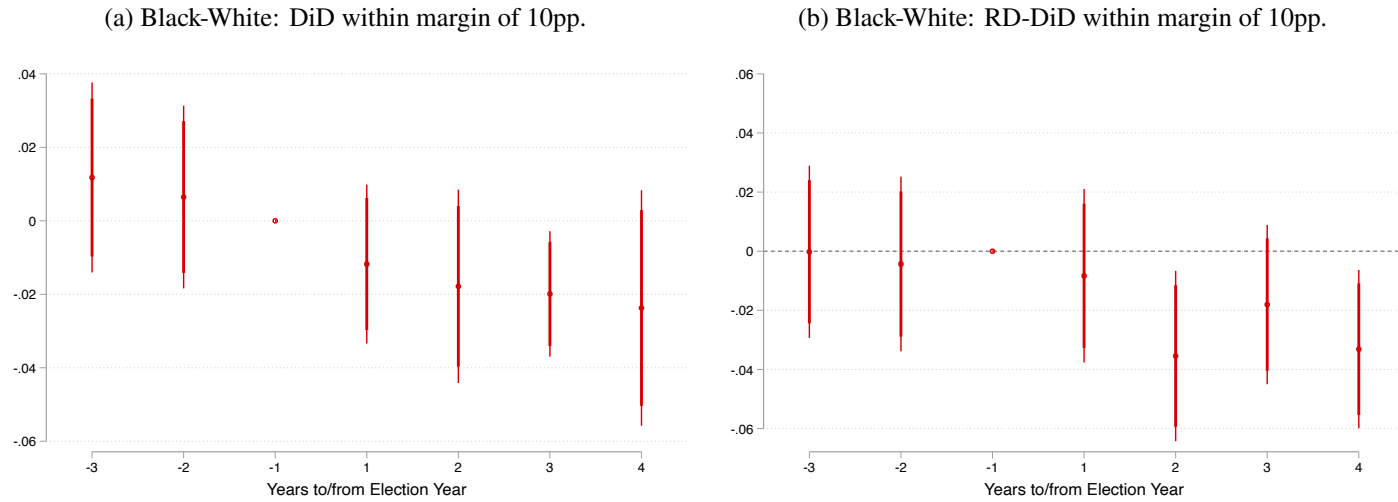


Figure 3: Event Studies: Action Taken, Black Drivers



Notes: “Action Taken” is a binary indicator equal to one if the driver receives a citation or is arrested, and zero if no action is taken or the driver receives a verbal or written warning. Specifications include month, police-agency, hour-of-stop, stop purpose, and election-contest fixed effects. Driver demographics include sex and age (entered as a second-degree polynomial). Standard errors are clustered at the police-agency level. Event-study estimates are reported relative to the year before a close election.

A ADDITIONAL RESULTS

Table A.1: Traffic Stops by Race, Purpose, and Action Taken.

	Race			
	Black	Latinx	White	Total
N	2,702,294 (42.4%)	545,682 (8.6%)	3,119,710 (49.0%)	6,367,686 (100.0%)
Purpose				
Checkpoint	29,160 (1.1%)	21,224 (3.9%)	27,486 (0.9%)	77,870 (1.2%)
Driving While Impaired	9,398 (0.3%)	4,883 (0.9%)	16,884 (0.5%)	31,165 (0.5%)
Investigation	113,417 (4.2%)	43,919 (8.0%)	99,986 (3.2%)	257,322 (4.0%)
Other Motor Vehicle Violation	116,636 (4.3%)	38,303 (7.0%)	110,641 (3.5%)	265,580 (4.2%)
Safe Movement Violation	174,532 (6.5%)	42,048 (7.7%)	235,622 (7.6%)	452,202 (7.1%)
Seat Belt Violation	79,086 (2.9%)	11,712 (2.1%)	99,198 (3.2%)	189,996 (3.0%)
Speed Limit Violation	710,036 (26.3%)	143,541 (26.3%)	1,115,246 (35.7%)	1,968,823 (30.9%)
Stop Light/Sign Violation	193,493 (7.2%)	42,423 (7.8%)	260,903 (8.4%)	496,819 (7.8%)
Vehicle Equipment Violation	408,486 (15.1%)	71,736 (13.1%)	371,343 (11.9%)	851,565 (13.4%)
Vehicle Regulatory Violation	868,050 (32.1%)	125,893 (23.1%)	782,401 (25.1%)	1,776,344 (27.9%)
Action				
Citation Issued	1,230,709 (45.5%)	320,060 (58.7%)	1,462,820 (46.9%)	3,013,589 (47.3%)
No Action Taken	90,676 (3.4%)	16,658 (3.1%)	83,667 (2.7%)	191,001 (3.0%)
On-View Arrest	68,772 (2.5%)	13,876 (2.5%)	53,368 (1.7%)	136,016 (2.1%)
Verbal Warning	967,812 (35.8%)	150,139 (27.5%)	1,040,241 (33.3%)	2,158,192 (33.9%)
Written Warning	344,325 (12.7%)	44,949 (8.2%)	479,614 (15.4%)	868,888 (13.6%)

Table A.2: Regression Discontinuity: Balance in Covariates at Cutoff

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
VARIABLES	Dem. Win	Repub. Win	Fem. Win	Pop: NW Share	Pop: Dem. Share
Nonwhite Win	0.530*** (0.154)	-0.183 (0.132)	0.009 (0.139)	0.005 (0.056)	-0.019 (0.048)
Observations	99	99	99	99	99
R-squared	0.204	0.121	0.019	0.007	0.003

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Table A.3: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Post-Stop Police Action, Different Bandwidths

VARIABLES	(1) BW=0.05	(2) BW=0.1	(3) BW=0.2
Post X NW Win	0.005 (0.034)	0.009 (0.025)	0.023 (0.016)
Post X NW Win X Black Driver	-0.019*** (0.006)	-0.023*** (0.005)	-0.016** (0.007)
Observations	974,882	1,168,763	2,176,684
R-squared	0.298	0.289	0.284
Core FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: "Action Taken" is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation or arrested; equal to zero if no action is taken or drivers receive a verbal or written warning. "Core FEs" includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. "Stop Purpose FEs" include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. "Driver Demos." includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table A.4: Action-Taken Rates in Treated and Control Municipalities, Overall and by Race

	Mean	SD	N
Control	0.501	0.500	719377
Treated	0.473	0.499	1450618
Control (White Drivers)	0.498	0.500	333179
Treated (White Drivers)	0.473	0.499	626707
Control (Black Drivers)	0.504	0.500	386198
Teated (Black Drivers)	0.473	0.499	823911

Table A.5: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Post-Stop Police Action, Party affiliation controls

VARIABLES	(1) Action Taken	(2) Action Taken	(3) Action Taken
Post X NW Win	0.071** (0.028)	0.043 (0.027)	0.022 (0.021)
Post X NW Win X Black Driver	-0.032*** (0.010)	-0.033*** (0.010)	-0.023*** (0.006)
Post X Dem Win	-0.184*** (0.030)	-0.144*** (0.026)	-0.113*** (0.016)
Post X DW Win X Black Driver	-0.008 (0.013)	-0.009 (0.012)	-0.007 (0.009)
Observations	1,181,398	1,170,449	1,168,763
R-squared	0.071	0.153	0.289
Core FE's	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FE's	No	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	No	Yes	Yes
Officer FE's	No	No	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: "Action Taken" is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation. "Core FEs" includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. "Stop Purpose FEs" include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. "Driver Demos." includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table A.6: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Post-Stop Police Action - Split by Racial Group

VARIABLES	(1) Action Taken	(2) Action Taken	(3) Action Taken	(4) Action Taken
Post X NW Win	0.019 (0.026)	0.003 (0.030)	0.019 (0.017)	0.029 (0.027)
Observations	1,289,805	615,046	119,356	555,403
R-squared	0.149	0.148	0.156	0.161
Core FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FEs	No	No	No	No
Method	DiD	DiD	DiD	DiD
Race Group	All	Blk.	Hisp.	Wht.

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: “Action Taken” is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation or arrested; equal to zero if no action is taken or drivers receive a verbal or written warning. “Core FEs” includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. “Stop Purpose FEs” include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. “Driver Demos.” includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table A.7: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Number of Offenses.

VARIABLES	(1) Total Offenses	(2) Index Offenses	(3) Property Offenses	(4) Violent Offenses
pXmw	-0.353 (0.432)	-0.236 (0.312)	-0.128 (0.271)	-0.108* (0.060)
Observations	902	902	902	902
R-squared	0.805	0.812	0.816	0.747
City	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Close Election Samp.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: Standard errors clustered at police-agency level.

Table A.8: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Number of Arrests.

VARIABLES	(1) Total Arrests	(2) Index Arrests	(3) Violent Arrests	(4) Property Arrests	(5) Drug Arrests
pXmw	-0.051 (0.307)	-0.021 (0.049)	-0.040 (0.099)	-0.027 (0.068)	-0.092 (0.099)
Observations	854	854	854	854	854
R-squared	0.781	0.750	0.791	0.784	0.728
City	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Close Election Samp.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: Standard errors clustered at police agency-level.

Table A.9: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Share of Black Being Arrested.

VARIABLES	(1) Total Arrests	(2) Index Arrests	(3) Violent Arrests	(4) Property Arrests	(5) Drug Arrests
pXmw	-0.006 (0.015)	0.015 (0.030)	-0.040* (0.021)	0.038 (0.031)	0.019 (0.039)
Observations	857	832	841	837	787
R-squared	0.899	0.796	0.822	0.789	0.721
City	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Close Election Samp.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: Outcome variables are shares of Black arrestees by arrest category. Standard errors are clustered at the police-agency level.

Table A.10: Placebo Test - Replicating Main Table from Manuscript Comparing White Challengers and White Incumbents.

VARIABLES	(1) Action Taken	(2) Action Taken	(3) Action Taken	(4) Action Taken
Post X Chall. Win	0.026 (0.071)	0.014 (0.064)	0.023 (0.057)	-0.012 (0.062)
Post X Chall. Win X Blk. Driver	-0.007 (0.031)	-0.009 (0.024)	-0.011 (0.010)	0.004 (0.014)
Observations	170,322	168,762	168,420	168,420
R-squared	0.081	0.177	0.288	0.288
Core FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes
Method	DiD	DiD	DiD	RD-DiD

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: “Action Taken” is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation or arrested; equal to zero if no action is taken or drivers receive a verbal or written warning. “Core FEs” includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. “Driver Demos.” includes sex and age (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police-agency level.

Table A.11: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Action Taken By Democratic Share.

VARIABLES	(1) Action Taken	(2) Action Taken	(3) Action Taken	(4) Action Taken
Post X NW Win	0.031 (0.028)	0.007 (0.022)	-0.009 (0.023)	-0.065*** (0.021)
Post X NW Win X Black Driver	-0.035** (0.014)	-0.036*** (0.012)	-0.023*** (0.008)	-0.020** (0.009)
Post X NW Win X demshare	0.085 (0.057)	0.085 (0.050)	0.054 (0.036)	-0.205*** (0.029)
Post X NW Win X Black Driver X demshare	-0.017 (0.029)	-0.003 (0.021)	-0.007 (0.014)	0.027 (0.026)
Observations	1,181,398	1,170,449	1,168,763	1,168,763
R-squared	0.070	0.153	0.289	0.289
Core FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Stop Purpose FEs	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Driver Demos.	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Officer FEs	No	No	Yes	Yes
Method	DiD	DiD	DiD	RD-DiD

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: “Action Taken” is a binary variable equal to one if drivers are given a citation or arrested; equal to zero if no action is taken or drivers receive a verbal or written warning. “Core FEs” includes month, agency, hour of stop, and election contest fixed effects. “Stop Purpose FEs” include the 10 major stop-purpose categories specified in Table A.1. “Driver Demos.” includes driver sex and age, (which enters as a second degree polynomial). Standard errors clustered at police agency level.

Table A.12: Municipality Characteristics Balance Check.

VARIABLES	(1) Population	(2) Black Population	(3) Black Share	(4) Median Income
NW Win	45,419.200 (45,010.125)	16,016.192 (15,700.242)	0.045 (0.060)	-2,691.853 (6,514.890)
Observations	223	223	223	223
R-squared	0.062	0.060	0.025	0.094
Close Election Samp.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors in parentheses

*** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1

Notes: The outcome variables are pre-election municipality-level population size (overall and African American), the share of Black residents, and median income. Year fixed effects are included. Standard errors are clustered at the city level.

Table A.13: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Council Meeting Topics.

Panel A. All elections						
VARIABLES	(1) All	(2) Police	(3) Stop	(4) Body camera	(5) Race	(6) Justice
Post $\times$ NW Win	51.361 (39.614)	15.840 (11.646)	0.764 (0.535)	0.668 (0.496)	14.556 (11.641)	19.533 (16.221)
Observations	137	137	137	137	137	137
R-squared	0.722	0.698	0.491	0.531	0.703	0.723
City	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Panel B. 10% margin sample						
VARIABLES	(1) All	(2) Police	(3) Stop	(4) Body camera	(5) Race	(6) Justice
Post $\times$ NW Win	168.892*** (8.069)	59.314*** (2.721)	2.171*** (0.173)	1.276*** (0.261)	45.652*** (2.433)	60.479*** (3.785)
Observations	48	48	48	48	48	48
R-squared	0.933	0.924	0.877	0.660	0.930	0.918
City	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Election	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Election and year fixed effects are included. Standard errors clustered at city council level.

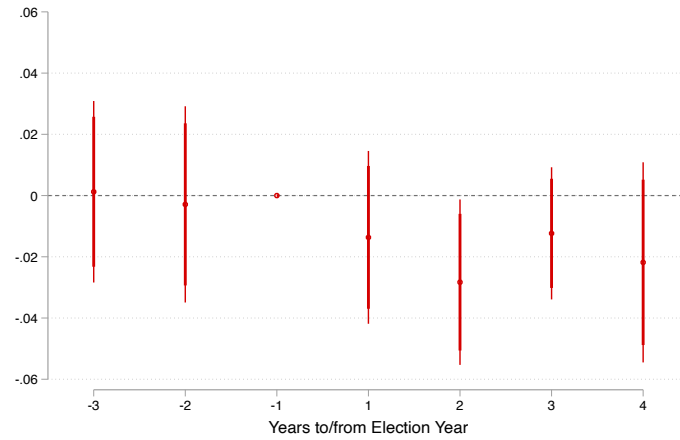
Table A.14: Impacts of Nonwhite Council Candidate Win on Police Chief Appointments.

Panel A. All elections			
VARIABLES	(1) Chief Change	(2) Nonwhite Chief	(3) Female Chief
Post $\times$ NW Win	0.064 (0.115)	-0.099 (0.179)	0.013 (0.148)
Observations	102	100	102
R-squared	0.341	0.765	0.381
Core FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Bandwidth	All elections	All elections	All elections
Panel B. 10% margin sample			
VARIABLES	(1) Chief Change	(2) Female Chief	
Post $\times$ NW Win	0.346* (0.136)	0.045 (0.108)	
Observations	27	27	
R-squared	0.660	0.349	
Core FEs	Yes	Yes	
Bandwidth	Close elections	Close elections	

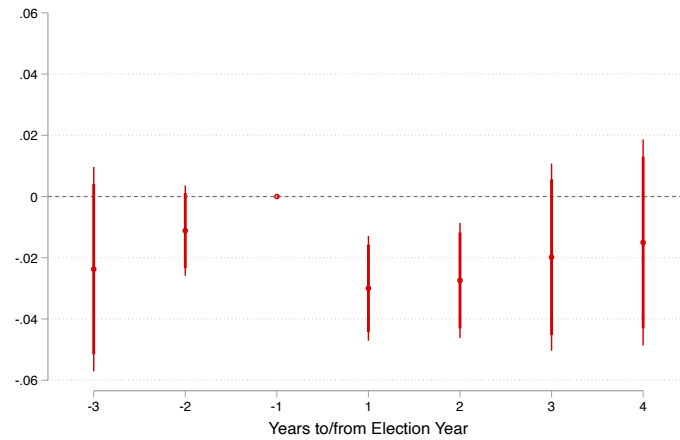
Notes: “Core FEs” includes year election contest fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at police-agency level.

Figure A.1: Event Studies: Action Taken, Multiple Bandwidths

(a) DiD within margin of 5pp.



(b) DiD within margin of 20pp.



Notes: “Action Taken” is a binary indicator equal to one if the driver receives a citation or is arrested, and zero if no action is taken or the driver receives a verbal or written warning. Specifications include month, police-agency, hour-of-stop, stop purpose, and election-contest fixed effects. Driver demographics include sex and age (entered as a second-degree polynomial). Standard errors are clustered at the police-agency level. Event-study estimates are reported relative to the year before a close election.